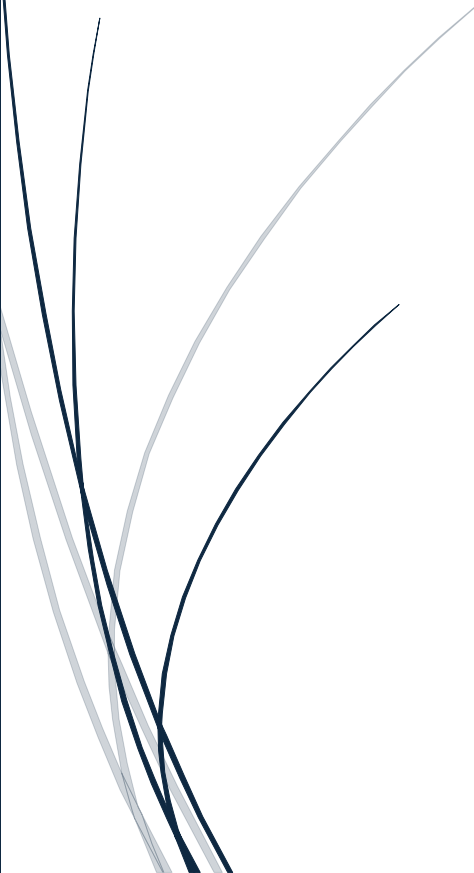




3/21/2024

Eriks operational manual for the DTG department

Operations



Erik Mickelson
NORTHWEST CUSTOM APPAREL

Introduction to the DTG Department Operational Manual

Welcome to the DTG Department Operational Manual, a comprehensive guide designed to support effective management within Northwest Custom Apparel. As the Operations Manager, you are pivotal in steering the department towards achieving our company's ambitious goals. This manual is your go-to resource for overseeing the DTG department, ensuring productivity, quality, and team cohesion.

The DTG (direct-to-garment) printing process is at the heart of our custom apparel offerings, combining technology, creativity, and precision to produce high-quality printed garments that meet our customers' diverse needs. As the demand for personalized apparel grows, the DTG department's efficiency and output quality become increasingly critical to our success.

This manual outlines the key roles within the department, including the expectations for each position, from the factory manager overseeing the operations to the DTG operators who bring our products to life. Additionally, it provides weekly checklists to ensure that essential tasks are completed, maintaining high standards of operation and product quality.

In the following sections, you'll find detailed guidelines on communication protocols, quality control measures, productivity benchmarks, and staff training and development strategies. These tools and insights are designed to empower you to manage the DTG department effectively, fostering an environment of accountability, continuous improvement, and excellence.

Whether you're addressing day-to-day challenges, strategizing for the department's future, or ensuring that your team is aligned and motivated, this manual is here to guide you. By adhering to the principles and practices outlined herein, you can lead the DTG department to new heights of success, contributing significantly to Northwest Custom Apparel's reputation for quality and innovation.

Let this manual be a foundation for your leadership, a reminder of your responsibilities, and a source of inspiration as you guide the DTG department forward. Together, we can achieve exceptional results, exceeding our customers' expectations and setting new standards in the custom apparel industry.

Department Overview

The Direct to Garment (DTG) Department at Northwest Custom Apparel represents a critical facet of our company's operations. Specializing in the innovative and fast-paced field of DTG printing, this department is tasked with producing high-quality, custom-printed garments that reflect our customers' diverse needs and preferences. From intricate designs to vibrant colors, DTG printing allows for a level of detail and color variation that sets our products apart in the competitive custom apparel market.

Purpose

The primary purpose of the DTG Department is to execute custom garment printing orders with precision and efficiency. By utilizing state-of-the-art DTG printers, we aim to deliver products that meet and exceed our customers' expectations in terms of quality, durability, and aesthetic appeal. This department is vital in fulfilling our commitment to innovation, quality, and customer satisfaction.

Scope of Operations

Operations within the DTG Department encompass a range of activities, from pre-production artwork preparation and machine setup to the actual printing process and post-production quality checks. The department is equipped with advanced DTG printing technology, enabling the production of prints on various garment types and materials, ensuring versatility and adaptability to market trends and customer demands.

Key Functions

- **Artwork Preparation:** Converting customer designs into print-ready files, ensuring compatibility with DTG printing requirements.
- **Machine Operation:** Efficiently running DTG printers, managing color profiles, and adjusting settings for optimal print quality.
- **Quality Control:** Conducting thorough inspections of printed garments to ensure each item meets our stringent quality standards before it reaches the customer.
- **Maintenance and Troubleshooting:** Performing regular maintenance on DTG printers and addressing any technical issues promptly to minimize downtime.
- **Order Fulfillment:** Ensuring timely production and delivery of DTG orders, coordinating with sales and customer service teams to manage expectations and communicate any delays or concerns.

Team Structure

The DTG Department is led by a Supervisor, currently Brian, who oversees the day-to-day operations and manages the department's sole operator, Joe. Together, they form a dedicated team committed to excellence in DTG printing. The Supervisor is responsible for coordinating production schedules, managing workflow, and ensuring the team meets productivity and quality goals. The Operator focuses on executing the printing tasks, maintaining equipment, and contributing to quality control efforts.

Strategic Importance

As personalized and custom-printed apparel continues to grow in popularity, the DTG Department's role within Northwest Custom Apparel becomes increasingly strategic. The ability to quickly and efficiently produce high-quality custom garments allows the company to respond effectively to market demands, attract a broader customer base, and maintain a competitive edge.

Staff Roles and Expectations

The DTG Department at Northwest Custom Apparel relies on a dedicated team to fulfill its operational goals and uphold the company's standards for quality and efficiency. Below are the roles within the department and the expectations for each position, ensuring clarity and accountability at all levels.

Ruthie - Factory Manager

Role Overview: Ruthie oversees the broader factory operations, including both the embroidery shop and the DTG Department. With 25 years of experience at Northwest Custom Apparel, she brings invaluable knowledge and leadership to the team.

Expectations:

1. **Strategic Oversight:** Ensure that the DTG Department aligns with the company's overall strategic goals, facilitating necessary resources and support.
2. **Performance Monitoring:** Regularly review operational and quality metrics from the DTG Department, providing guidance to improve efficiency and product quality.
3. **Leadership Development:** Mentor Brian in his supervisory role, reinforcing leadership skills and the importance of maintaining a professional work environment.

Brian - DTG Supervisor

Role Overview: Brian is responsible for the day-to-day management of the DTG Department. His role is crucial for overseeing production, ensuring quality, and leading the department's sole operator, Joe.

Expectations:

1. **Operational Efficiency:** Maintain daily production logs, manage machine uptime, and ensure the department meets its productivity targets.
2. **Quality Assurance:** Implement and oversee quality control processes, ensuring all outputs meet the company's high standards.
3. **Team Leadership:** Act as a role model for Joe, clearly distinguishing the supervisory role from personal relationships, and fostering a culture of professionalism and accountability.

Joe - DTG Operator

Role Overview: Joe operates the DTG printing machinery, playing a key role in producing the custom-printed garments. As the primary operator, his focus on productivity and quality is essential for the department's success.

Expectations:

1. **Productivity:** Operate DTG machines efficiently, minimizing downtime and striving to meet or exceed daily production goals.
2. **Quality Control:** Conduct initial quality checks on prints and address any issues to ensure the final product aligns with quality standards.
3. **Machine Maintenance:** Perform regular cleaning and maintenance on the DTG printers, reporting any significant issues to Brian for further action.

Weekly Checklists for Accountability

To reinforce these expectations, each role is accompanied by a simplified weekly checklist:

- **Ruthie's Checklist:**
 - Conducted strategic review of DTG operations with Brian.
 - Reviewed production and quality metrics for continuous improvement.
 - Provided leadership coaching to Brian, focusing on team management and operational excellence.

- **Brian's Checklist:**
 - Maintained and reviewed daily production logs for efficiency insights.
 - Conducted quality checks, ensuring all outputs meet the required standards.
 - Led by example, fostering a professional work environment and providing clear direction to Joe.
- **Joe's Checklist:**
 - Achieved productivity targets with minimal machine downtime.
 - Performed quality control checks on initial prints and adjusted as necessary.
 - Completed regular maintenance on DTG printers, ensuring optimal operation.

Communication and Check-Ins

Effective communication and regular check-ins are the backbone of a well-functioning DTG Department at Northwest Custom Apparel. These practices ensure that everyone is aligned with the department's goals, aware of their responsibilities, and engaged in continuous improvement. Here's how communication and check-ins are structured within the DTG Department:

Between Ruthie and Brian

- **Bi-Weekly One-on-One Meetings:** Ruthie and Brian are expected to meet twice a week to discuss the DTG Department's operational status, challenges, and opportunities. These meetings provide a platform for strategic planning, performance review, and problem-solving.
 - **Agenda Items:**
 - Review of production logs and operational efficiency.
 - Updates on quality control measures and outcomes.
 - Discussion of team dynamics and any personnel issues.
 - Planning for upcoming projects and setting priorities.
- **Ad-Hoc Communication:** In addition to scheduled meetings, Ruthie and Brian should maintain open lines of communication for any urgent issues or updates. This

can be facilitated through email, phone calls, or messaging platforms, ensuring timely responses to immediate needs.

Between Brian and Joe

- **Daily Briefings:** At the start of each shift, Brian should brief Joe on the day's production targets, any specific focus areas for quality, and updates on equipment or operational changes. This ensures Joe starts his day with clear expectations and priorities.
 - **Key Focus Areas:**
 - Production goals and any special project instructions.
 - Quality control reminders and specific checks to perform.
 - Maintenance tasks or adjustments to standard procedures.
- **End-of-Day Debriefs:** Brian and Joe should also have brief end-of-day meetings to review the day's achievements, discuss any issues encountered, and plan for the next day. This allows for immediate feedback and adjustment of strategies as needed.

Documentation and Feedback

- **Production Logs and Reports:** Brian is responsible for maintaining detailed production logs, which should be shared with Ruthie during their bi-weekly meetings. These logs provide a basis for assessing productivity and identifying areas for improvement.
- **Feedback Mechanism:** Implementing a structured feedback mechanism within the DTG Department encourages the sharing of ideas, concerns, and suggestions for improvement. This can be facilitated through regular team meetings, suggestion boxes, or digital feedback platforms.

Quality Control and Productivity

Maintaining the highest standards of quality control and ensuring peak productivity are paramount in the DTG Department at Northwest Custom Apparel. These principles not only reflect our commitment to excellence but also directly impact customer satisfaction and operational efficiency. Here's how we approach these crucial aspects:

Quality Control Measures

- **Regular Quality Checks:** Brian, with assistance from Joe, is responsible for conducting regular, thorough quality checks on all DTG prints. This includes assessing each print's clarity, color accuracy, and overall quality against established standards.
- **Immediate Correction of Issues:** Any quality issues identified during checks are to be immediately addressed. Solutions may involve adjusting printer settings, recalibrating color profiles, or redoing prints that do not meet quality expectations.
- **Continuous Improvement:** Feedback from quality checks is used for immediate corrections and long-term improvements in processes and techniques. This iterative approach ensures ongoing enhancement of our DTG printing quality.

Productivity Optimization

- **Efficient Workflow Management:** Brian is tasked with creating and maintaining an efficient workflow that minimizes downtime and maximizes output without compromising quality. This includes effective scheduling of jobs, ensuring timely maintenance of equipment, and optimizing the layout and setup of the DTG printing area.
- **Production Logs:** Detailed production logs are kept by Brian, documenting the quantity of garments printed, machine usage times, and any downtime or issues encountered. These logs are crucial for identifying patterns that affect productivity and areas where efficiency can be improved.
- **Goal Setting and Monitoring:** Setting clear, achievable production goals for the DTG department and monitoring progress towards these goals is essential. Ruthie and Brian review these goals during their bi-weekly meetings, adjusting strategies as needed to meet or exceed targets.

Accountability and Training

- **Responsibility for Standards:** Brian is held accountable for both the quality and productivity of the DTG department. This accountability is reinforced through Ruthie's oversight and the bi-weekly one-on-one meetings where department performance is a key focus.
- **Ongoing Training:** Recognizing that technology and best practices evolve, ongoing training for both Brian and Joe is essential. Whether it's new printing techniques,

maintenance procedures, or software updates, continuous learning ensures the team can maintain high productivity and quality standards.

Accountability and Performance Monitoring

Ensuring accountability and effective performance monitoring within the DTG department is crucial for maintaining Northwest Custom Apparel's standards of excellence. Here are the strategies for overseeing the performance of Brian, the DTG Supervisor, and Joe, the DTG Operator, as well as the process for addressing any instances of underperformance or misconduct.

Strategies for Monitoring and Evaluating Performance

1. **Setting Clear Performance Objectives:** Begin by establishing clear, measurable objectives for both Brian and Joe that align with the department's goals. These should cover areas such as productivity, quality control, leadership effectiveness, and professional conduct.
2. **Regular Performance Reviews:** Conduct structured performance reviews on a regular basis, such as quarterly or semi-annually. Use these sessions to assess progress toward objectives, discuss any challenges, and set goals for the next review period.
3. **Real-Time Feedback and Coaching:** Encourage Ruthie to provide Brian and Joe with real-time feedback and coaching, addressing issues as they arise rather than waiting for scheduled reviews. This approach fosters a culture of continuous improvement and immediate problem-solving.
4. **Utilization of Performance Metrics:** Leverage daily production logs, quality control records, and other relevant metrics to objectively evaluate Brian and Joe's performance. These data points can highlight areas of success as well as opportunities for further development.
5. **Peer and Self-Assessments:** Incorporate peer reviews and self-assessments into the performance evaluation process. These perspectives can provide additional insights into Brian and Joe's performance and areas for improvement.

Addressing Underperformance or Misconduct

1. **Identifying the Issue:** Clearly identify the nature of the underperformance or misconduct. Determine whether it's a lack of skills, knowledge, motivation, or a violation of workplace policies.

2. **Initial Discussion:** Ruthie should have a direct and confidential conversation with the individual (Brian or Joe) to discuss the observed performance issues or misconduct. It's important to listen to their side and understand any underlying factors contributing to the issue.
3. **Developing an Improvement Plan:** Together, create a specific, time-bound improvement plan that outlines the steps needed to address the performance gaps or correct the misconduct. This plan may include additional training, adjusted responsibilities, or clear behavioral expectations.
4. **Monitoring Progress:** Regularly monitor the individual's progress against the improvement plan, providing support and adjustments as needed. Recognize and reinforce positive changes in performance or behavior.
5. **Taking Disciplinary Action:** If there's no improvement or if misconduct continues, implement disciplinary actions in line with company policies. These actions should be progressive, starting with verbal warnings and potentially leading to written warnings, suspension, or even termination if necessary.

Conclusion: Navigating the Path Forward in the DTG Department

Throughout our discussions, we've outlined a comprehensive framework designed to enhance the operational efficiency, quality control, and team dynamics of the DTG Department at Northwest Custom Apparel. This framework establishes clear expectations and accountability for key personnel, including Ruthie, Brian, and Joe, while providing a structured approach to communication, training, and performance monitoring.

Key Takeaways

Setting Clear Expectations: The cornerstone of effective management in the DTG Department involves setting clear, measurable expectations for each team member. Ruthie's strategic oversight, Brian's operational efficiency and leadership, and Joe's productivity and adherence to quality standards form the basis of the department's success.

Structured Communication and Check-Ins: Regular, structured communication through bi-weekly one-on-one meetings between Ruthie and Brian, as well as daily briefings and debriefs between Brian and Joe, ensure that operational goals are aligned, and any issues are promptly addressed.

Emphasis on Quality and Productivity: Maintaining high-quality outputs and optimizing productivity are non-negotiable standards for the DTG Department. Implementing rigorous quality checks and leveraging production logs are critical for meeting these standards.

Ongoing Training and Development: Recognizing the rapid advancements in DTG technology and the importance of leadership skills, investing in continuous training and development for Brian and Joe is essential. This fosters innovation, problem-solving, and a culture of continuous improvement.

Accountability and Performance Monitoring: Establishing a culture of accountability involves regular performance evaluations, real-time feedback, and a clear process for addressing underperformance or misconduct. Ruthie's role in monitoring and guiding Brian and Joe is pivotal to ensuring that departmental and individual performance meets the company's high standards.

Looking Ahead

As the Operations Manager, Erik, your leadership is instrumental in guiding the DTG Department toward achieving its operational goals and contributing to the overall success of Northwest Custom Apparel. By focusing on these key areas and maintaining open lines of communication with Ruthie, you empower her to effectively manage the DTG Department, fostering an environment of accountability, excellence, and continuous growth.

In essence, this operational framework outlines the current state and immediate steps for enhancing the DTG Department's efficiency and output and sets a strategic path for long-term success. Your trust in Ruthie's management capabilities and your strategic oversight will ensure that the DTG Department remains a vital, productive asset to Northwest Custom Apparel.

Remember, the strength of our team lies in our commitment to our core values, our willingness to embrace change and challenges, and our collective drive towards

excellence. By adhering to the principles outlined in this framework, we are well-positioned to navigate the path forward, achieving outstanding results for our customers and setting new benchmarks in the custom apparel industry.